

Dart and null safety

Classes, null-safe types and collections

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Week 4

Lab objectives



Null safety in code

When to use `?`, `?.`, `??` and `late`

TIME

2 hours



Classes and inheritance

Model a small domain with an abstract base class and two subclasses

SUBMIT

Push to `admd-labs`, branch `lab-2`, before Lab 3

Branch and file layout

1. Open the project from Lab 1 and create a branch:

```
git checkout -b lab-2
```

2. Create `lib/models/` directory. All classes live there.
3. One class per file with `lower_snake_case` filenames: `user.dart`, `bank_account.dart`, etc.
4. Only `main.dart` holds widget code: just enough to display what your classes produce.

Hint

Dart convention: lowercase filename for lowercase class. The graders read your repository by these rules.

Null-safety types and operators

Types and operators

`String?`: may be null; plain `String` never can

`?.`: read a member only if non-null

`??`: use right-hand value if left is null

`?!=`: assign only if currently null

`!`: assert non-null; throws if wrong

Declarations and promotion

`late`: assigned after construction

`required`: caller must pass it

`= 0.0`: default for optional parameter

`is Book`: type test that promotes variable

`x != null`: flow analysis promotes to non-null

Prefer `?.`, `??` and null checks over `!`. The compiler cannot check a value asserted with `!`.

Null safety example

```
class Room {  
    final String code;           // always present  
    final int? seats;           // may be unknown  
    String? projector;          // may be absent  
    late final DateTime opened;  // set later, read after  
  
    Room({required this.code, this.seats, this.projector});  
  
    String describeSeats() =>  
        seats == null ? 'Unknown' : '$seats seats';  
}
```

`code` never null. `seats`, `projector` may be null, so compiler forces handling. `opened` has no value yet; reading it throws `LateInitializationError`.

TASK I

Users

1. Create `User` with `String name`, `int? age`, `String? email`.
 2. Make `name` required; leave `age`, `email` optional.
 3. Create three `User` instances with different null combinations.
 4. Display safely; show “Not provided” where value is null.
 5. Implement `getDisplayAge()`: return “Age not specified” or age as string.
-

DONE WHEN

- ☐ Three users render, one with all optionals null
- ☐ Both branches of `getDisplayAge()` work

TASK II

Bank accounts

1. Create `BankAccount`: late `accountNumber`, required `holderName`, `balance = 0.0`.
 2. Add optional `bankBranch`.
 3. Implement `initializeAccount(String number)`.
 4. Add method to check if account number is set.
 5. Display accounts safely in `ListView`.
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DONE WHEN

- ☐ All accounts render with branch or "N/A"
- ☐ Uninitialized account shows message

Minimal UI for the models

```
ListView.builder(  
  itemCount: accounts.length,  
  itemBuilder: (context, i) {  
    final a = accounts[i];  
    return ListTile(  
      title: Text(a.holderName),  
      subtitle: Text(a.bankBranch ?? 'Not provided'),  
    );  
  },  
)
```

Widgets are Lecture 3 and Lab 3. Build visible rows only. `??` handles “Not provided” in widgets.

Library: model classes

1. Abstract `LibraryItem`: `title`, `author?`, `publishDate?`.
 2. `Book` extends `LibraryItem`: add `pageCount?`, `isbn?`.
 3. `Magazine` extends `LibraryItem`: add `issueNumber?`, `publisher?`.
 4. Pass shared fields via super constructor.
 5. Add `borrower?` (reuse Task I `User`) and `dueDate?` to `LibraryItem`.
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DONE WHEN

- ☐ Both subclasses compile without unset fields
- ☐ All optional fields use `?`

Library: API and borrowing

1. `Library` holds `List<LibraryItem>`; add `addItem()` with validation.
 2. Implement `searchByTitle()`, `getItemsByAuthor()`, `getRecentItems()` with null handling.
 3. Add `borrowItem()` that checks if already borrowed.
 4. Add `returnItem()` that clears borrower and `dueDate`.
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DONE WHEN

- ☐ All methods handle null safely
- ☐ Borrowed items are protected
- ☐ Null queries return empty list

Common errors

Non-nullable 'x' not assigned before use

Give a value, use `?`, or mark `late`

LateInitializationError on 'x'

A `late` field read before it was set

Can't access property on nullable receiver

Use `?.`, `??`, or null check first

Null check `!` used on null value

Replace with `??` or real null check

Type 'String?' can't assign to 'String'

Promote with `if (x != null)` or `??`

Submission

Branch lab-2 · one commit per task